

ON THE CAMPAIGN TRAIL
CM N. Biren Singh in Saikul, Kangpokpi district, Manipur

CHANDRADEEP KUMAR

MANIPUR

BJP COMES INTO ITS OWN

THE BJP VICTORY IN MANIPUR RESTED ON ITS GOVERNMENT'S SUCCESS IN CLAMPING DOWN ON VIOLENCE, DELIVERY OF WELFARE SCHEMES AND AN OPPOSITION IN DISARRAY

By KAUSHIK DEKA

IN AN EXCLUSIVE INTERVIEW with INDIA TODAY almost a year ago, Chief Minister N. Biren Singh said: "We (the BJP) are working towards winning the next assembly poll on our own." That mission now accomplished, he can heave a sigh of relief. The most important result of this victory is that his position remains safe for now—which is why he had aimed at not just winning, but securing a solo majority too.

In his first tenure, Biren Singh faced multiple challenges for his position as chief minister, both from members of his own party and from allies, particularly the NPP (National People's Party). Now, with the BJP having a majority of its own, troubles from allies will be minimised. More importantly, since this incremental victory (from 21 seats in 2017 to 32 now) was achieved under Biren Singh's leadership, the BJP's unlikely to name someone else chief minister, even though no chief ministerial candidate was announced going into the polls.

HOW THE BJP WON MANIPUR

If the BJP government in Manipur can claim one undisputed achievement, it is the massive drop in terror-related incidents in the state. Not long ago, all Manipur—including state capital Imphal—would come to a standstill after sunset. In the past five years, it has enjoyed a period of relative peace. In 2017, the year Biren Singh took charge, 55 people (including 23 civilians)